5.1. Creating And Using PivotTables

To create a PivotTable, you need to have your data source ready first. This could be an Excel Table, a range of cells that contain the data you require, or an external data source like an Access database.

Click anywhere inside your source data, select the Insert tab, click the PivotTable button, and select either PivotTable or PivotChart. If you select PivotChart, it will create a chart based on your data elements selection (see later in this section for more on data element selection). However, it is better to create your PivotTable before delving into charts—this will give a better idea of how your data looks, and you can fine-tune your data view before making the charts. The chart option is useful when you are ready with your data and you are certain about how your PivotTable should be and all you need to do is quickly make your chart.

In the Create PivotTable Wizard's pop-up window, the range will get automatically selected, and the radio button "Select a table or range" will be highlighted. You can change the range by clicking back on the worksheet and selecting a new area, or by manually entering the cell references. You can also take a reference from a different worksheet or workbook. If your source data is in a different worksheet, switch to that worksheet and select the range there. However, you typically will not need to do this as you can just switch to the source data worksheet and run the PivotTable Wizard, which will prompt you to create a new worksheet. If you want your PivotTable in a different workbook, open that workbook as well as your source data workbook first. Run the PivotTable Wizard in your target workbook (the workbook where the PivotTable will be created), click inside the "Table/Range:" field, and switch to the workbook with the data and select the range.

You can also specify a name for the source data range, or convert it into an Excel table and use the table name. Using tables can be very useful when your source data keeps changing. As data gets